

Cybersecurity for SME Employees

Module 2.2 – Recognizing and Avoiding Phishing Attempts

1 Introduction

Phishing is one of the most common and dangerous cyber threats facing businesses today. Attackers use phishing to trick individuals into revealing sensitive information or performing harmful actions. This module helps employees recognize the signs of phishing and adopt strategies to avoid falling victim.

2 What is Phishing?

Phishing is a type of cyber attack that uses fraudulent messages to manipulate recipients into:

- Clicking malicious links.
- Downloading harmful attachments.
- Providing credentials or sensitive information.
- Making unauthorized transactions.

3 Types of Phishing Attacks

3.1 1. Email Phishing

The most common form, involving fake emails that appear to come from trusted sources.

3.2 2. Spear Phishing

Targeted phishing directed at specific individuals using personal information to increase credibility.

3.3 3. Whaling

Phishing attacks aimed at executives or high-level personnel.

3.4 4. Smishing and Vishing

- **Smishing:** Phishing through SMS/text messages.
- **Vishing:** Voice phishing using phone calls to impersonate authority figures.

4 How to Recognize Phishing

- **Urgency or Threats:** “Act now or lose access!” or “Your account will be suspended.”
- **Suspicious Links:** Hovering over links shows a different URL.
- **Unusual Requests:** Asking for login credentials, payments, or personal information.
- **Poor Grammar or Formatting:** Obvious errors or strange formatting.
- **Unknown or Misspelled Sender Addresses:** Slight changes in domain names (e.g., amaz0n.com).

5 What To Do If You Suspect Phishing

- Do not click on any links or download attachments.
- Do not reply to the message.
- Report the email to your IT or security team immediately.
- Delete the message if confirmed malicious.

6 Best Practices to Prevent Phishing

- Think before clicking—when in doubt, verify with the source.
- Use email filters and anti-phishing software.
- Enable multi-factor authentication (MFA) on all accounts.
- Keep systems and browsers updated to block known threats.

7 Example Scenario

You receive an email from “IT Support” requesting a password reset. The email contains a link to a login page. You notice the URL reads “it-supp0rt.com.” Instead of clicking, you contact IT, who confirms it’s a phishing attempt. Your cautious response prevents a potential breach.

8 Conclusion

Phishing attacks rely on human error. Employees who stay informed and alert are key to stopping these threats. Recognizing red flags and knowing how to respond can prevent major incidents. In the next module, we’ll look at password security and how it forms the foundation of digital protection.